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Beating an incumbent mayor a very tall order

To oust Wu, Kraft would have to snap a 76-year Boston tradition

By Niki Griswold

GLOBE STAFF

The year was 1947, and James Michael Curley, Boston's legendary "rascal king," had just returned to City Hall after serving time in federal prison for mail fraud during his fourth term as mayor.

"I have accomplished more in one day than has been done in the five months of my absence," he boasted at the end of his first day back.

But his hubris proved to be too much for voters: When Curley

sought reelection in 1949, voters ousted him in favor of then-City Clerk John B. Hynes.

Such is the power of incumbency in Boston: It took a conviction and prison sentence to unseat Curley, and in the 76 years that followed, not a single incumbent has lost, even when he appeared vulnerable. It is a historical record that philanthropist Josh Kraft must grapple with as he seeks to displace the current incumbent, Mayor Michelle Wu, the first woman and person of color elected to lead the city.

To be sure, there are no guarantees in politics, and Kraft has a number of advantages that could help balance the scales. As a son of the billionaire owner of the Patriots, Kraft is likely to benefit from higher-than-usual name recognition for a first-time candidate, as well as access to virtually unlimited funds, whether from his own pocket or those of his wealthy connections.

Still, more than seven decades of election results show Kraft faces long odds in his bid to unseat Wu amid the benefits incumbency

brings.

Kraft appears clear-eyed about the task at hand.

"I enter this race as an underdog, and I know this is going to be an uphill fight, but I'm excited for the challenge," Kraft said at his Feb. 4 campaign launch.

The incumbency advantage has translated into a relatively small number of Boston mayors over the past 76 years, given that most of them have stayed in office for multiple terms.

The division and unrest sparked by court-ordered desegregation of

INCUMBENTS, Page A10

Democrats shift, and shutdown is averted

Party sharply split about best way to resist Trump

By Catie Edmondson and Carl Hulse

NEW YORK TIMES

WASHINGTON — The Senate on Friday narrowly averted a government shutdown at midnight, passing a GOP-written stopgap spending measure after minority leader Chuck Schumer of New York and a small group of Democrats joined Republicans in allowing it to advance.

The final vote to pass the spending measure, which would fund the government through Sept. 30, was 54-46, nearly along party lines. But the key vote came earlier, when after days of Democratic agonizing, Schumer and nine other members of his caucus supplied the votes needed to allow it to move ahead, effectively thwarting a filibuster by their own party in a bid to prevent a shutdown.

The action came just hours before a midnight deadline to avoid a lapse in funding.

The spending debate inflamed intraparty tensions among Democrats that have simmered for weeks about how to mount the most effective resistance to President Trump at a time when he is taking full advantage of his governing trifecta — control of the White House, Senate, and House — to trample on congressional power, slash federal funding, and fire government workers with little regard for the guardrails that normally constrain the executive branch.

Schumer's abrupt decision to reverse himself and allow the spending legislation to advance stunned many of his colleagues and angered many Democratic lawmakers and progressive activists who were spoiling for a shutdown fight to

SHUTDOWN, Page A6

IRS's progress likely sacrificed to DOGE ax

By Jim Puzzanghera

GLOBE STAFF

WASHINGTON — For the first time in about a decade, things were looking up for the Internal Revenue Service last year.

A funding boost in 2022 had started reversing years of staffing and enforcement problems. A new focus on millionaires with large past-due tax payments brought in \$1.1 billion in the fiscal year that ended Sept. 30, the agency said. The hiring of additional customer service representatives allowed the IRS to answer almost 9 million more phone calls than two years earlier and many branches added night and weekend hours, according to the agency's independent National Taxpayer Advocate. The agency even launched an ambitious pilot program that allowed people in Massachusetts, New Hampshire, and 10 other states to prepare and file their federal returns online for free.

Now those improvements could be reversed as the Trump administration's aggressive budget-cutting effort has hit the IRS just as the April 15 filing deadline approaches, raising concerns about delays in processing returns and sending out refunds.

"This is not an agency that is doing something superfluous. It's a core government function," said Mark W. Everson, who served as IRS commission-

IRS, Page A6



PHOTOS BY BRETT PHELPS FOR THE BOSTON GLOBE

Matt Milley did laps in the 75-foot-long indoor pool in the Millennium Residences at Winthrop Center, in the Financial District.

UP ABOVE IT ALL

The sky is the new status neighborhood, with amenities you wouldn't dream of



Club VIP is a pet day care and wellness spa in the Millennium Residences offering such treats as aromatherapy facials.

By Beth Teitell

GLOBE STAFF

It was frigid out, and so icy that all over town pedestrians were tumbling. But on the 35th floor of the Millennium Residences at Winthrop Center, life felt as easy as a summer afternoon, and Richard Baumert was marveling at the lap pool: 75 feet long, surrounded by floor-to-ceiling windows, its water a bewitching shade of . . . let's call it *conciergerie blue*.

"You're doing laps in the sky!" exclaimed Baumert, the managing partner of Millennium Partners. He sounded as awed as a child — and as strategic as a developer positioning his building against rival luxury buildings. "This is a huge draw for people."

Down on earth, where rents have grown punishing and some Bostonians are being pushed from their homes, affordable housing has become a central issue in the mayoral campaign.

But in the sky — the city's new status neighborhood — the fight is not over meeting the basic needs of life, but over lifestyle. It's a war of amenities. On beast mode.

In a world where two-bedroom condos routinely go

AMENITIES, Page A7

Alleged clients of brothel in the spotlight

12 men are publicly identified, charged, but only 2 attend hearing

By Sean Cotter, Danny McDonald, and Nick Stoico

GLOBE STAFF

CAMBRIDGE — After months of speculation and judicial rigmarole, some of the men accused of buying sex through a Cambridge-area brothel ring that operated out of luxury apartments were publicly identified in court on Friday.

The dozen men charged with allegedly paying for sex hail from disparate backgrounds. A twenty-something radiographer who grew up in Concord and works at a major Boston hospital. A Natick dentist. A software engineer from Waltham who is going through a divorce. A Winchester man in his mid-50s who has worked for a pharmaceutical giant.

In the 16 months since authorities dismantled the brothel ring and vowed accountability for the men who kept it running through payments of hundreds of dollars an hour for sex

BROTHELS, Page A10



JOHN TLUMACKI/GLOBE STAFF

Survivors of the commercial sex industry (from left) Brittanie Adams, Audra Doody, Audrey Morrissey, and Stacy Reed watched a live broadcast of the proceedings Friday.



The Ides have it

Saturday: Warming up. High 52-57. Low 44-49.

Sunday: Still warm, showers. High 61-66. Low 51-56.

Weather and Comics, D4-5. Obituaries, C9.

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President Vladimir Putin insisted that Ukraine order some of its forces to surrender, hours after President Trump said the United States had "productive" discussions with him about a possible cease-fire. **A4.**

Senators pressed Dr. Mehmet Oz, nominated to head Medicare and Medicaid, on proposals that would significantly affect the health care coverage for half of all Americans. **A2.**

Governor Maura Healey announced new limits on who can enter the state's emergency shelter system. **B1.**

South Boston leaders warned St. Patrick's visitors to behave, saying there will be "zero tolerance" after last year. **B1.**